



About this overview. This document is an example of how the course might be taught. Scholars may see some variation in topics and projects from course to course, and between the live school and On-Demand. Each teacher also leans into their own strengths and passions; the structure, expectations, and time commitment below are representative of the course as designed.

This year-long course teaches your scholar to think, read, reason, and argue like an intellectual. Across five modules they move from practical study skills to careful reasoning, close reading, and building a defended argument of their own. The work is hands-on: every topic pairs a lesson with a written assignment and an immersive VR activity on Optima's VR campus, and three of the modules build toward a real project scholars present at the end.

THE YEAR AT A GLANCE — 5 MODULES

Module	Lessons	Focus & module project
1 · Preparing Like an Intellectual	4	Study skills: time management and goal-setting, active reading, note-taking and memory, research, presenting, test prep
2 · Acting Like an Intellectual	8	Communication and "soft skills," adapting, navigating differences, and telling facts from opinions
3 · Thinking Like an Intellectual	9	Scientific reasoning, evidence, confidence in beliefs, and spotting bad logic; project: the Good Life Experiment
4 · Reading Like an Intellectual	8	Reading like a scholar, summarizing across sources, citing with integrity; project: Annotated Bibliography
5 · Arguing Like an Intellectual	3	Building, evaluating, and refining arguments; course final: the Disputatio

A TYPICAL WEEK

Piece	What the scholar does (~50 min/day, M–F)
Lesson	Read the lesson page : short readings with interactive "try-it" practice built in.
Write	A written assignment in Microsoft Word applying the lesson, saved to OneDrive and turned in through Canvas.
VR	A hands-on VR activity on Optima's VR campus that pairs with the lesson.
Wrap	Each module opens with a quick ungraded check-in survey and closes with a reflection.

TIME COMMITMENT

250 minutes per week is the school's designated planning figure for this course: about 50 minutes a day, Monday through Friday. The lesson, the written assignment, and the VR activity are the core of that time. **Project weeks** (Modules 3–5) can run longer.

MODULE PROJECTS

- ▶ **Good Life Experiment (M3)**: scholars run a real week-long experiment on themselves, keep a daily data log, build a VR research lab, and present findings in a science-paper-format video
- ▶ **Annotated Bibliography (M4)**: evaluate and annotate a curated set of sources inside a VR research library, then give a guided tour
- ▶ **The Disputatio (M5, course final)**: choose a topic, research the debate, build an argument in a VR arena, answer counter-arguments, fact-check, and defend a position

WHAT SCHOLARS NEED

- ▶ **VR headset** for the weekly immersive activities on Optima's VR campus
- ▶ **Microsoft 365** (Word, Excel) through the Optima account; work saves to OneDrive
- ▶ **On AI**: scholars learn to use AI as a tool, not a substitute; they drive the thinking and verify every important claim themselves
- ▶ **Group option**: each module, scholars may opt into a study group for the main assignment

NOTES FOR FAMILIES

On-Demand (asynchronous). This course is built for the On-Demand scholar: lessons, assignments, and VR activities are self-paced with due dates for pacing, designed to be completed independently. A teacher is available throughout for support, feedback, and grading.

Live school. Scholars enrolled in the live school work through this same course in VR every school day, together with a teacher and classmates.